

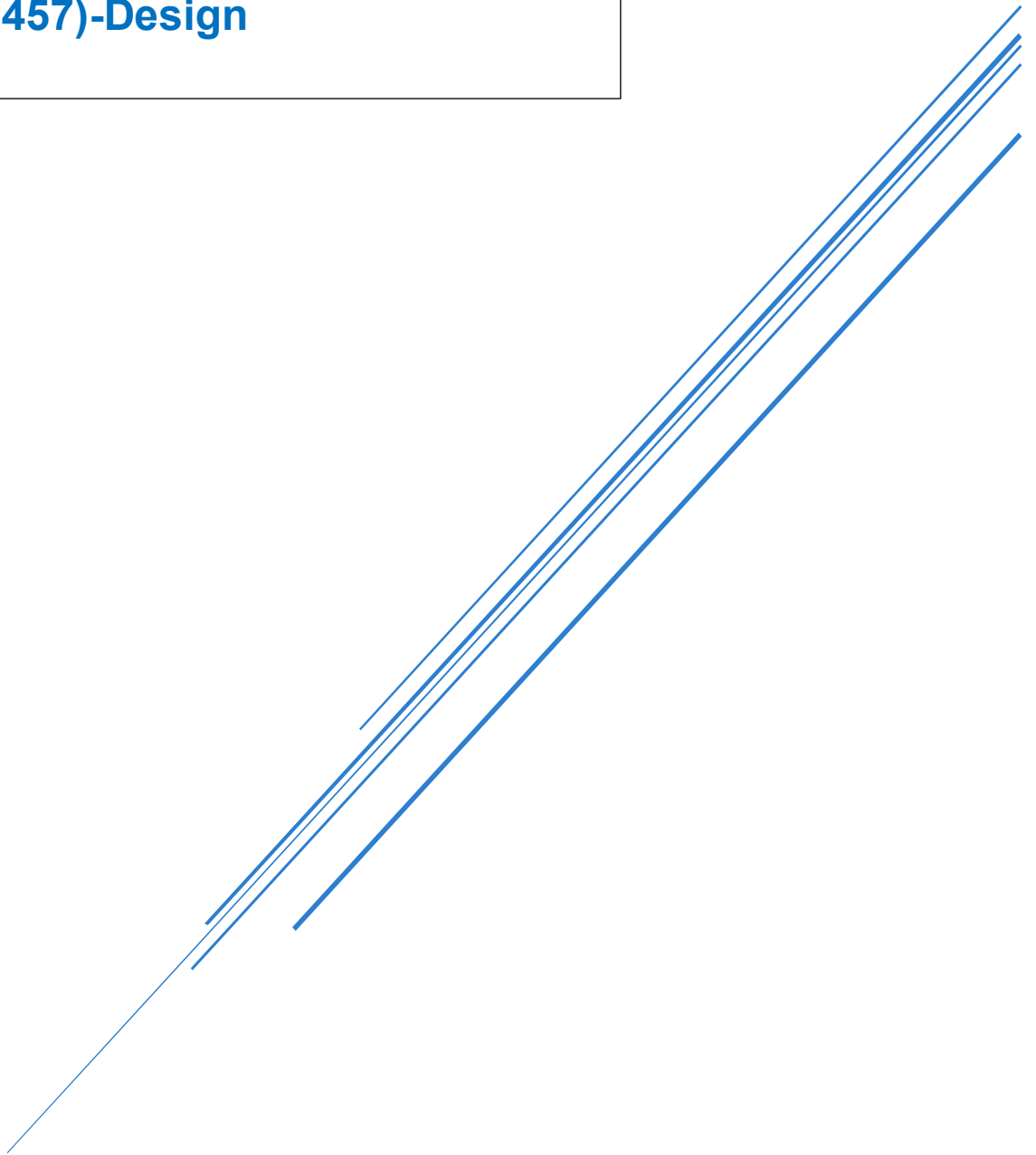
OPSC6311 PART 1

Research

**Mufhumudzi Rasilingwana
(St10441516) -Research**

**Oluga Neluvhalani (St10443034)-
Planning**

**Luthando Princess Mndawe
(St10446457)-Design**



1. Introduction

Financial management has never been more important in today's digital world, especially for people who want to manage their spending, save, and develop good financial habits. Thanks to the development of mobile apps, financial management has never been more efficient.

The project in this report focuses on researching three financial management apps: Zaka Manager, Vault22, and Good budget. These apps provide different features, ideas, and tools to assist people in managing their financial activities successfully. The aim of the research project is to evaluate the advantages, disadvantages, and special features of the three apps in order to determine the key success factors that make an effective budgeting app.

By analysing the three apps, the study in this report attempts to determine the best features from the three apps that can be integrated to create an improved financial management application as part of the Practical Assessment Task (POE).

2. App Research

App 1: Zaka Manager

1. What is Zaka Manager

Zaka Manager is an application for financial management that was designed in South Africa and is intended for working-class individuals who want to manage their expenses and budgets and improve their financial literacy. This application utilizes artificial intelligence and machine learning to analyse bank transaction messages and categorize expenses without requiring users to access their bank accounts. Instead, it uses bank SMS notifications or account statements to identify transactions and generate financial reports. The main aim of this application is to improve financial literacy and facilitate financial planning and decision-making without requiring complex financial instruments such as spreadsheets.

Key purposes of the app include:

- Tracking income and expenses
- Creating personal budgets
- Providing financial insights and reports
- Helping users control spending habits

2. Key Strengths of Zaka Manager

2.1. No Need to Share Banking Credentials

One of the biggest advantages of the app is that it doesn't require users to enter their banking credentials. Instead, it utilizes the content of the bank notifications it receives.

2.2. AI-Powered Expense Tracking

The app utilizes machine learning to track expenses based on the content of the bank notifications received. This enables users to receive automatic reports on the spending of their money.

2.3. Budget Management Tools

The app allows users to create their own budgets with custom start and end dates. Additionally, the app sends notifications to users when they are about to exceed their budget.

2.4. Additional Financial Utilities

Aside from the budgeting feature, the app provides users with additional financial utilities such as: Bill splitting, Shopping lists, Debt analysis tools

2.5. Strong Security Features

The app uses several security mechanisms including: Encrypted storage, AES-256 encrypted cache, Biometric authentication (fingerprint or face recognition), Secure TLS network communication

3. Weaknesses and Limitations

3.1. Limited Platform Availability

The app is only available for Android devices currently, which makes it inaccessible for iOS users.

3.2. Dependence on SMS Notifications

The app heavily relies on bank SMS notifications for transaction detection. If bank SMS notifications are not enabled, the app will not function properly.

3.3. Relatively New Startup

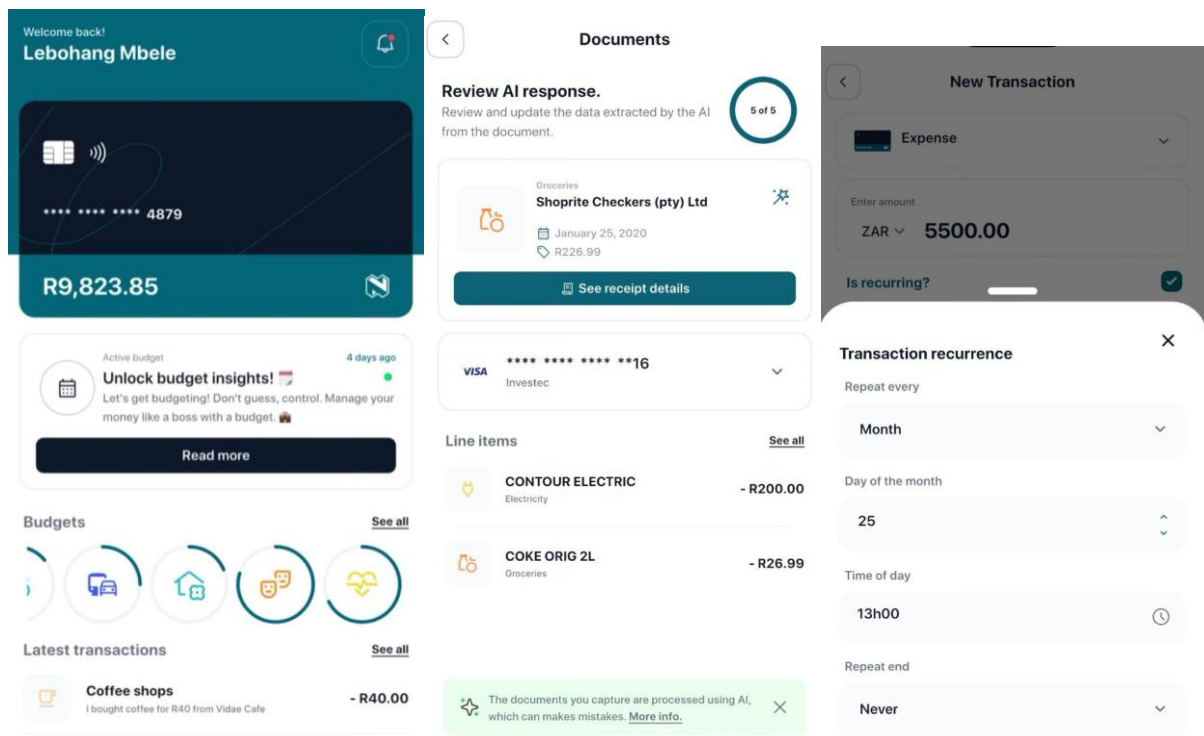
Since this app is a relatively new startup, it may not have the same maturity level as other financial apps.

3.4. Subscription Pricing

Some of its advanced features require users to pay for a subscription, which might deter users who prefer free financial management apps.

4. Navigation and Screenshots

1. Dashboard / Home Screen
2. Transactions Screen
4. Financial Reports Screen
5. Tools Section
6. Settings and Security



App 2: Vault22

1. What is Vault22

Vault22 is a financial management and budgeting application made and primarily used South Africa. It evolved from an earlier budgeting tool called 22seven and is now supported by investors connected to Old Mutual and Standard Chartered's innovation arms (SC Ventures and NEXT176) (Vault22, 2024).

The app's purpose is to help individuals track, manage, and grow their finances responsibly and in a fun way too. It does this by linking bank accounts, credit cards, loans, investments, and rewards accounts into one interface so that users can see their entire financial situation or state all in one place.

Once the accounts have been linked, the system automatically imports transactions and categorises spending such as groceries, transport, entertainment or any other category of your choice.

Typical functions include:

1. Automatic budgeting
2. Spending analytics
3. Financial goal tracking
4. Investment opportunities
5. Financial literacy tools

2. Key Strengths of Vault22

2.1 Financial aggregation (seeing everything in one place)

One of the most powerful features of the app is financial aggregation. Vault22 allows users to connect over 120 financial institutions, including major banks such as Capitec, FNB, ABSA, and Standard Bank.

This then means the app can display bank accounts, credit cards, loans, investments, insurance products inside a single dashboard. This matters because without aggregation, users must log into multiple bank apps to understand their financial position which can be time consuming and dreading. Aggregation reduces this friction and improves financial awareness. This concept is known in fintech as “360-degree financial visibility.”

2.2 Automatic categorisation of spending

When transactions are imported, the system automatically categorises them into spending groups such as groceries, transport, rent and entertainment. The software then generates spending reports.

This is important because many people fail at budgeting simply because they do not know where their money goes or how much they have spent on a specific category. Now automatic categorisation therefore reduces the manual effort required to track finances.

2.3 Financial education and guidance

Vault22 also provides financial learning materials and behavioural nudges designed to improve financial habits.

For example, the app may alert users when they are close to exceeding a budget, suggest strategies for paying off debt and encourage savings goals.

This then helps integrate financial literacy with financial tracking, which is relatively uncommon in simple budgeting apps.

3. Weaknesses and Limitations

3.1 Dependence on bank access permissions

To work properly, the app requires access to bank data which then creates a trade-off such as better financial insights but increases privacy concerns. This does make some users uncomfortable sharing financial credentials with third-party platforms.

3.2 Learning period for budgeting

The platform typically requires 2–3 weeks to analyse spending patterns before generating accurate insights. Which means the experience may initially feel incomplete.

3.2 Bugs and stability complaints

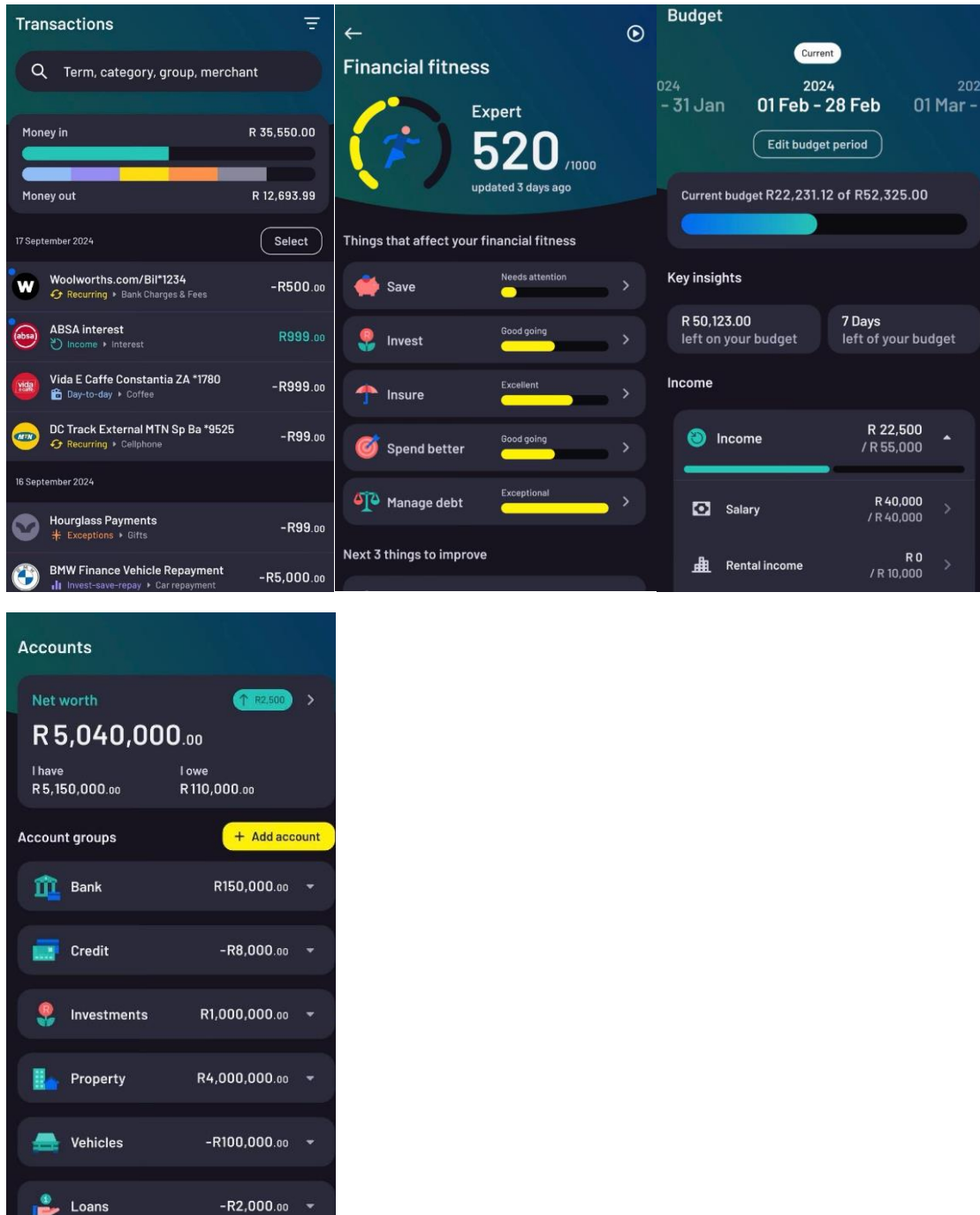
The app has glitches, inaccurate budgets, inconsistent updates and in community forums. While this does not affect all most people, it highlights the challenge of maintaining complex financial aggregation systems.

4. Navigation and screenshots

1. Dashboard / Home
2. Transactions
3. Budget / Insights

4. Goals / Savings

5. Profile / Settings



App 3: Goodbudget

1. What is Goodbudget

Goodbudget is an application that is meant for personal budgeting and tracking of expenses for individuals who are interested in managing their finances through an envelope budgeting system. The application allows users to set budgets for various spending categories such as groceries, rent, transport, and entertainment, among others.

Unlike most financial management apps that connect to bank accounts, Goodbudget is more focused on manual input of financial transactions, thus encouraging users to be more aware of their spending habits. The app is available on Android, iOS, and web platforms.

The main aim of the application is to encourage users to plan their spending and develop good financial discipline.

Typical functions include:

- Budget planning
- Expense tracking
- Spending categorisation
- Savings goal tracking
- Budget progress reports

2. Key Strengths of Goodbudget

2.1 Envelope Budgeting System

The most distinctive aspect of Goodbudget is its envelope budgeting system. Users are required to set up different envelopes for various categories of spending. When users spend money on anything, the application deducts the amount from the respective envelope. If the envelope is depleted of funds, users are not allowed to continue spending on that item.

2.2 Financial Awareness

Since users are required to enter all their spending into the application, they are more likely to be financially aware. The application also offers users the option of viewing financial reports and charts that show spending patterns.

2.3 Multi-Device Budget Tracking

Goodbudget allows users to track their budgets on various devices.

3. Weaknesses and Limitations

3.1 Manual Data Entry

The drawback of the app is that the transactions need to be manually entered into the app.

3.2 Limited Features in Free Version

The free version of the app has limited features, where the premium version contains additional features like unlimited envelopes and history.

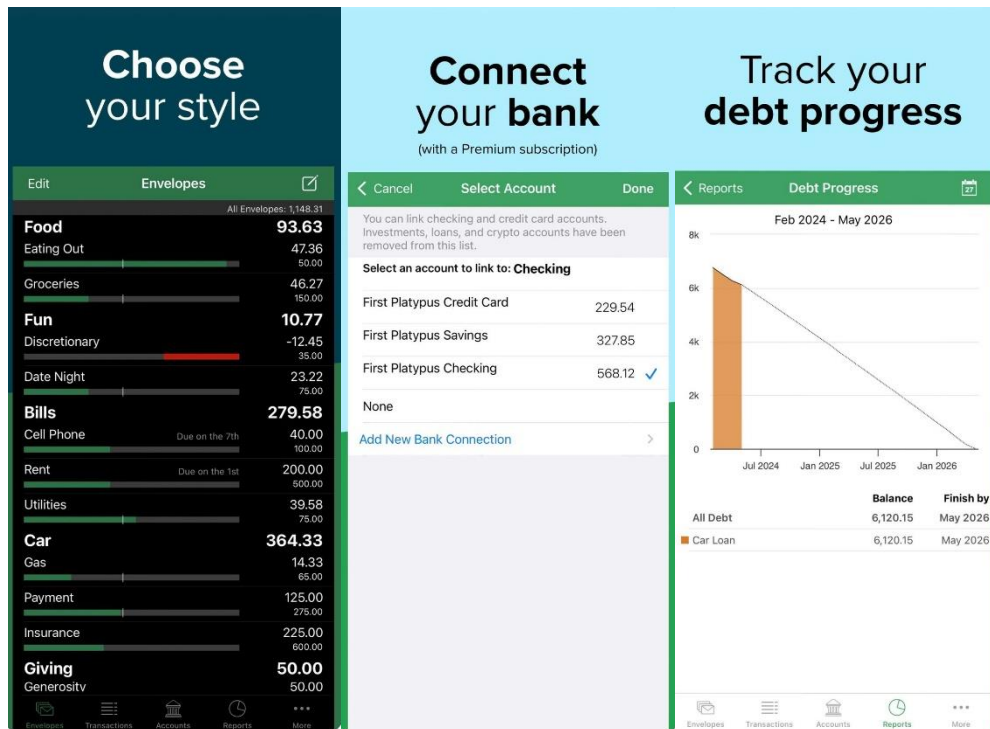
3.3 No Automatic Bank Sync in Free Version

The free version does not allow the app to automatically connect to the bank accounts like other apps.

5. Navigation and Screenshots

The main sections include:

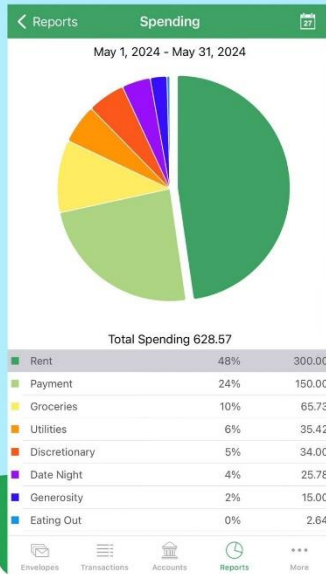
- Dashboard (overview of envelopes and balances)
- Transactions page
- Budget envelopes
- Reports and charts
- Settings and account management



Stay on budget



See your spending



Create a budget that works

Edit Budget Done

Food		
Eating Out	50	
Groceries	150	
Fun		
Discretionary	35	
Date Night	75	
Bills		
Cell Phone	100	
Rent	500	
Utilities	75	
Car		
Gas	65	
Payment	275	
Insurance	50	600 Annually
Giving		
Generosity	50	
+ Add Envelope		
Monthly >	Total Budgeted 1508	

Sync & share a budget

Edit Envelopes

All Envelopes: 1,148.31

Food	93.63
Eating Out	47.36
Groceries	46.27
Fun	10.77
Discretionary	-12.45
Date Night	23.22
Bills	279.58
Cell Phone	40.00
Rent	200.00
Utilities	39.58
Car	364.33
Gas	14.33
Payment	125.00
Insurance	225.00
Giving	50.00
Generosity	50.00

Envelopes Transactions Accounts Reports More

Save for big expenses

< Envelopes Vacation

Vacation 2,000.00

You have saved 2,000.00 so far.

Wed	May 1, 2024
Fill Envelopes	+50.00
Fill from [Available]	
Tue	Apr 16, 2024
Cash Gift from Mom	+100.00
Vacation Checking	
Mon	Apr 1, 2024
Fill Envelopes	+75.00
Fill from [Available]	
Fri	Mar 1, 2024
Income	+320.00
Vacation Checking	
Thu	Feb 1, 2024
Income	+150.00
Vacation Checking	
Mon	Jan 1, 2024
Income	+50.00
Vacation Checking	
Fri	Dec 1, 2023
Income	+75.00
Vacation Checking	

Envelopes Transactions Accounts Reports More

3. Comparison of all three apps

Feature	Vault22	Zaka Manager	Goodbudget
Primary Purpose	Complete financial wellness platform	Budget tracking + financial utilities	Envelope-style budgeting system
Target Users	People who want automatic financial tracking across accounts	Users wanting simple budgeting without sharing bank credentials	Individuals or families using traditional envelope budgeting
Bank Account Integration	Links 120+ banks and financial institutions	No direct banking details required (uses statements & notifications)	Bank sync only in premium version
Budgeting Method	Automatic categorization and spending insights	Flexible budgets with alerts	Envelope budgeting (digital categories)
Expense Tracking	Automatic tracking and categorization	Manual / imported tracking	Manual entry (auto sync in paid plan)
Extra Tools	Net worth tracking, investment options, debt management	Bill splitting, shopping list, debt analysis	Debt payoff tracking, spending reports
Collaboration / Sharing	Mainly individual financial tracking	Mostly individual use	Supports multi-device sharing for families
Reports & Insights	Personalized financial insights and spending comparisons	AI-powered insights and budget alerts	Charts showing spending vs envelopes
Security Features	Bank-grade encryption and secure account linking	AES-256 encryption, biometric login	256-bit encryption like financial institutions
Cost	Mostly free	Usually free / basic mobile app	Free version + Premium subscription

4. Best feature from each of the apps

1. Zaka Manager:

SMS-Based Transaction Detection

- Tracks expenses without needing bank login details
- Increases privacy and security
- Still allows automatic expense tracking using AI

2. Vault22:

Automatic Transaction Categorisation

- Categorises spending (groceries, transport, etc.) automatically
- Works perfectly with SMS data (does NOT require bank login if adapted)

3. Goodbudget:

Envelope Budgeting System

- Divides money into categories (envelopes)
- Helps users control spending strictly

5. Conclusion

In conclusion, based on the analysis of Zaka Manager, Vault22, and Goodbudget, it is evident that each application has a unique way of managing finances. Zaka Manager is based on privacy and convenience using SMS tracking, Vault22 is based on a comprehensive and automated financial overview using bank integration, and Goodbudget is based on discipline using an envelope budgeting system.

Each application has its advantages and disadvantages that make it effective and inefficient in different aspects. From the analysis of the applications, it is evident that no application is perfect on its own, but the integration of the most effective features in each application can create an even more powerful and effective application. This research has provided an excellent foundation in the creation of a new financial management application that is based on automation, security, and discipline.

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